

HTML Details & Summary Tags

Complete Guide: Easy English Edition

Master collapsible content and accordion patterns with native HTML

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1 Introduction

The HTML `<details>` and `<summary>` tags create native collapsible/expandable content without JavaScript. They're semantic, accessible, and built into all modern browsers!

1.1 What are Details and Summary?

- **`<details>`**: Container for collapsible content
- **`<summary>`**: The clickable header/title
- **Native Toggle**: Built-in expand/collapse
- **Semantic HTML**: Proper markup structure
- **Accessibility**: Automatic ARIA support

1.2 Why Use Details/Summary?

- **No JavaScript**: Works without scripts
- **Semantic**: Proper HTML meaning
- **Accessibility**: Built-in ARIA roles
- **Easy to Use**: Simple HTML structure
- **Keyboard Support**: Tab and Enter work
- **Customizable**: Full CSS control
- **Performant**: Lightweight solution

2 Basic HTML Structure

2.1 Simple Example

```
<details>
  <summary>Click to expand</summary>
  <p>Hidden content appears here!</p>
</details>
```

2.2 Complete Structure

```
<details>
  <!-- The clickable header -->
  <summary>What is this?</summary>

  <!-- The hidden content -->
  <p>This is the answer to the question.</p>
  <p>You can include any HTML here!</p>
</details>
```

2.3 Required Elements

Element	Purpose	Required
<details>	Container	Yes
<summary>	Clickable header	Yes
Content	Hidden content	No

3 Details Attributes

3.1 Open Attribute

The open attribute shows details by default:

```
<!-- Closed by default -->
<details>
  <summary>Click me</summary>
  <p>Hidden content</p>
</details>

<!-- Open by default -->
<details open>
  <summary>Already expanded</summary>
  <p>Content is visible</p>
</details>
```

3.2 Other Attributes

```
<!-- With ID for JavaScript -->
<details id="faq-1">
  <summary>Question?</summary>
  <p>Answer</p>
</details>

<!-- With class for styling -->
<details class="accordion-item">
  <summary>Title</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>

<!-- With data attributes -->
<details data-section="faq">
  <summary>Item</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>
```

4 Summary Tag

4.1 Simple Summary

```
<details>
  <summary>Simple Text</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>
```

4.2 Rich Summary Content

```
<details>
  <summary>
    <strong>Important:</strong> Click here
  </summary>
  <p>More details...</p>
</details>
```

```
<details>
  <summary>
    <span class="icon">→</span>
    Expandable Section
  </summary>
  <p>Content here</p>
</details>
```

4.3 Summary with Multiple Elements

```
<details>
  <summary>
    <h3>Question Title</h3>
    <span class="meta">Updated 2024</span>
  </summary>
  <p>Detailed answer</p>
</details>
```


5 Real-World Examples

5.1 Example 1: FAQ Section

```
<section class="faq">
  <h2>Frequently Asked Questions</h2>

  <details>
    <summary>What is this service?</summary>
    <p>This service provides...</p>
  </details>

  <details>
    <summary>How do I get started?</summary>
    <p>To get started, you need...</p>
  </details>

  <details>
    <summary>What is the pricing?</summary>
    <p>Our pricing is...</p>
  </details>
</section>
```

5.2 Example 2: Accordion Menu

```
<div class="accordion">
  <details class="accordion-item">
    <summary>Product Features</summary>
    <ul>
      <li>Feature 1</li>
      <li>Feature 2</li>
      <li>Feature 3</li>
    </ul>
  </details>

  <details class="accordion-item">
    <summary>Pricing Plans</summary>
    <p>We offer three plans...</p>
  </details>

  <details class="accordion-item">
    <summary>Support</summary>
    <p>Contact us at support@example.com</p>
  </details>
</div>
```

5.3 Example 3: Nested Details

```
<details>
  <summary>Main Category</summary>

  <details>
    <summary>Subcategory 1</summary>
    <p>Content 1</p>
  </details>

  <details>
    <summary>Subcategory 2</summary>
    <p>Content 2</p>
  </details>
</details>
```

5.4 Example 4: Product Specifications

```
<div class="product">
  <h2>Product Name</h2>

  <details>
    <summary>Specifications</summary>
    <table>
      <tr><td>Weight</td><td>500g</td></tr>
      <tr><td>Color</td><td>Blue</td></tr>
    </table>
  </details>

  <details>
    <summary>Shipping Info</summary>
    <p>Ships within 2-3 business days</p>
  </details>

  <details>
    <summary>Returns & Warranty</summary>
    <p>30-day money back guarantee</p>
  </details>
</div>
```

6 CSS Styling

6.1 Basic Styling

```
details {  
  border: 1px solid #E0E0E0;  
  border-radius: 8px;  
  padding: 15px;  
  margin-bottom: 10px;  
}  
  
summary {  
  cursor: pointer;  
  font-weight: bold;  
  user-select: none;  
}  
  
summary:hover {  
  color: #2196F3;  
}
```

6.2 Styling Open State

```
details[open] {  
  background-color: #F5F5F5;  
  border-color: #2196F3;  
}  
  
details[open] summary {  
  color: #2196F3;  
  border-bottom: 2px solid #2196F3;  
  padding-bottom: 10px;  
  margin-bottom: 10px;  
}
```

6.3 Animated Arrow

```
summary::marker {  
  color: #2196F3;  
}  
  
/* Custom arrow with CSS */  
details summary::-webkit-details-marker {  
  display: none;  
}
```

```
details summary::before {
  content: →'';
  display: inline-block;
  margin-right: 10px;
  transition: transform 0.3s;
}

details[open] summary::before {
  transform: rotate(90deg);
}
```

6.4 Dark Mode Support

```
details {
  border: 1px solid #E0E0E0;
  background: white;
}

@media (prefers-color-scheme: dark) {
  details {
    border-color: #444;
    background: #2d2d2d;
    color: #f0f0f0;
  }

  summary {
    color: #e0e0e0;
  }

  summary:hover {
    color: #66ccff;
  }
}
```

7 Advanced Styling

7.1 Accordion Styling

```
.accordion {  
  border: 1px solid #E0E0E0;  
  border-radius: 8px;  
  overflow: hidden;  
}  
  
.accordion-item {  
  border: none;  
  border-bottom: 1px solid #E0E0E0;  
  border-radius: 0;  
  margin: 0;  
  padding: 0;  
}  
  
.accordion-item:last-child {  
  border-bottom: none;  
}  
  
.accordion-item summary {  
  padding: 15px;  
  background: #F9F9F9;  
  font-weight: 500;  
}  
  
.accordion-item[open] summary {  
  background: #F0F0F0;  
  border-bottom: 2px solid #2196F3;  
}  
  
.accordion-item > :not(summary) {  
  padding: 15px;  
  background: white;  
}
```

7.2 Card Style

```
details.card {  
  border: none;  
  border-radius: 12px;  
  box-shadow: 0 2px 8px rgba(0, 0, 0, 0.1);  
  overflow: hidden;  
}
```

```

details.card summary {
  padding: 20px;
  background: white;
  cursor: pointer;
}

details.card[open] summary {
  background: #F5F5F5;
  border-bottom: 1px solid #E0E0E0;
}

details.card > :not(summary) {
  padding: 20px;
  border-top: 1px solid #E0E0E0;
}

```

7.3 With Icons

```

details {
  padding: 15px;
  border-radius: 8px;
  border: 1px solid #E0E0E0;
}

summary {
  display: flex;
  align-items: center;
  gap: 10px;
  cursor: pointer;
  font-weight: 500;
}

summary::before {
  content: '';
  display: inline-block;
  transition: transform 0.3s;
  color: #2196F3;
}

details[open] summary::before {
  transform: rotate(90deg);
}

```

8 JavaScript Integration

8.1 Detecting Open/Close

```
<details id="myDetails">
  <summary>Click me</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>

<script>
const details = document.getElementById('myDetails');

// Check current state
if (details.open) {
  console.log('Open');
} else {
  console.log('Closed');
}

// Listen for toggle
details.addEventListener('toggle', (e) => {
  if (e.target.open) {
    console.log('Details opened');
  } else {
    console.log('Details closed');
  }
});
</script>
```

8.2 Programmatic Control

```
const details = document.getElementById('myDetails');

// Open
details.open = true;

// Close
details.open = false;

// Toggle
details.open = !details.open;
```

8.3 Single Open Accordion

```
<script>
```

```
const accordion = document.querySelectorAll('.accordion-item');

accordion.forEach(item => {
  item.addEventListener('toggle', (e) => {
    if (e.target.open) {
      // Close all others
      accordion.forEach(other => {
        if (other !== e.target) {
          other.open = false;
        }
      });
    }
  });
});
</script>
```

8.4 Smooth Animation

```
<style>
details {
  overflow: hidden;
}

details > :not(summary) {
  animation: slideDown 0.3s ease-out;
}

details[open] > :not(summary) {
  animation: slideDown 0.3s ease-out;
}

@keyframes slideDown {
  from {
    opacity: 0;
    transform: translateY(-10px);
  }
  to {
    opacity: 1;
    transform: translateY(0);
  }
}
</style>
```


9 Accessibility

9.1 Built-in Accessibility

```
<!-- Automatically accessible! -->
<details>
  <summary>Accessible by default</summary>
  <p>Keyboard navigation works</p>
  <p>Screen readers understand</p>
</details>

<!-- Arrow shows open/closed state -->
<!-- Tab navigation works -->
<!-- Enter/Space toggles -->
```

9.2 Enhanced Accessibility

```
<details id="faq-1">
  <summary aria-label="Question about pricing">
    Pricing FAQ
  </summary>
  <div id="faq-1-answer">
    <p>Our pricing starts at \$10/month</p>
  </div>
</details>
```

9.3 Semantic Enhancement

```
<section aria-label="Frequently Asked Questions">
  <details>
    <summary>What is your service?</summary>
    <p>We provide web solutions</p>
  </details>

  <details>
    <summary>How much does it cost?</summary>
    <p>Pricing varies by plan</p>
  </details>
</section>
```

10 Browser Support

10.1 Compatibility

Browser	Support
Chrome	12+
Firefox	49+
Safari	15.1+
Edge	79+
Opera	15+
IE	NOT SUPPORTED

10.2 Polyfill for IE

```
<!-- For IE 11 and older browsers -->
<script
  src="https://cdn.jsdelivr.net/npm/details-element-polyfill@2.4.0/dist/details-element"
```

11 Common Patterns

11.1 Pattern 1: Simple FAQ

```
<section class="faq">
  <h2>FAQ</h2>

  <details>
    <summary>Question 1?</summary>
    <p>Answer 1</p>
  </details>

  <details>
    <summary>Question 2?</summary>
    <p>Answer 2</p>
  </details>
</section>

<style>
.faq details {
  margin-bottom: 10px;
  padding: 15px;
  border: 1px solid #E0E0E0;
  border-radius: 8px;
}

.faq summary {
  cursor: pointer;
  font-weight: bold;
}
</style>
```

11.2 Pattern 2: Product Details

```
<div class="product-details">
  <details open>
    <summary>Description</summary>
    <p>Product description text</p>
  </details>

  <details>
    <summary>Specifications</summary>
    <ul>
      <li>Feature 1</li>
      <li>Feature 2</li>
    </ul>
  </details>
</div>
```

```
<details>
  <summary>Shipping</summary>
  <p>Free shipping on orders over \ $50</p>
</details>
</div>
```

11.3 Pattern 3: Menu Navigation

```
<nav>
  <details>
    <summary>Products</summary>
    <ul>
      <li><a href="/product1">Product 1</a></li>
      <li><a href="/product2">Product 2</a></li>
    </ul>
  </details>

  <details>
    <summary>Support</summary>
    <ul>
      <li><a href="/help">Help Center</a></li>
      <li><a href="/contact">Contact</a></li>
    </ul>
  </details>
</nav>
```

12 Common Mistakes

12.1 Mistake 1: Missing Summary

DON'T:

```
<details>
  <p>No summary!</p>
</details>
```

DO:

```
<details>
  <summary>Click to expand</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>
```

12.2 Mistake 2: Multiple Summaries

DON'T:

```
<details>
  <summary>First</summary>
  <summary>Second</summary>
  <p>Only first is used!</p>
</details>
```

DO:

```
<details>
  <summary>One Summary</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>
```

12.3 Mistake 3: No Default State

Problem: User doesn't know content exists

Solution:

```
<!-- First item open for discovery -->
<details open>
  <summary>First item (open by default)</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>

<details>
  <summary>Other items (closed)</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>
```

13 Quick Reference

13.1 Basic HTML

```
<!-- Simple collapsible -->
<details>
  <summary>Title</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>

<!-- Open by default -->
<details open>
  <summary>Title</summary>
  <p>Content</p>
</details>
```

13.2 Essential CSS

```
details {
  border: 1px solid #E0E0E0;
  border-radius: 8px;
  padding: 15px;
}

summary {
  cursor: pointer;
  font-weight: bold;
}

details[open] summary {
  color: #2196F3;
}
```

13.3 Key Points

- `<details>` is the container
- `<summary>` is the clickable header
- Built-in toggle (no JS needed)
- Semantic HTML
- Accessible by default
- Full CSS customization

- `open` attribute for default state
- Works with all modern browsers

Conclusion

The `<details>` and `<summary>` tags provide a native, semantic way to create collapsible content. They're perfect for FAQs, accordions, and any expandable content.

Key Takeaways:

- Use `<details>` and `<summary>` for collapsible content
- No JavaScript required
- Fully accessible by default
- Customizable with CSS
- Works in all modern browsers
- Perfect for FAQs and product details

Start using native details/summary for cleaner, more accessible collapsible content!